

Different Yardsticks

The voter perceptions at the national and the state levels varied vastly. Mayawati, ranked fourth nationally, occupied the 18th and last slot at the state level.

	National Ranking	State Ranking
NARENDRA MODI	1	6
SHEILA DIKSHIT	2	4
NITISH KUMAR	3	5
MAYAWATI	4	18
YSR REDDY	5	8
M. KARUNANIDHI	6	14
ASHOK CHAVAN	7	13
B. BHATTACHARYA	8	17
V.S. ACHUTHANANDAN	9	16
S.S. CHOUHAN	10	6
NAVEEN PATNAIK	11	1
ASHOK GEHLOT	12	9
RAMAN SINGH	13	2
B.S. HOODA	14	12
P.S. BADAL	15	10
TARUN KUMAR GOGOI	16	15
DIGAMBAR KAMAT	17	
B.C. KHANDURI	18	3

between 20 and 25 per cent of the votes. In contrast, the rating of most chief ministers outside their respective states remained in single digits. Modi scored exceptionally well in states like Karnataka, Haryana, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and even communist Kerala. Barring the first, all are non-BJP ruled states which are on high growth trajectories.

In Rajasthan, Modi got 35 per cent votes as against 38 per cent of local Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot, while in Uttar Pradesh, he was not too far behind Mayawati who, just a over

a year ago, became the first chief minister to win an absolute majority in 20 years. Besides the cross-border support, Modi's backers belong to all three age groups surveyed: 18-24, 25-44 and 45 upwards and is spread equally across the illiterate, the moderately educated though there is a skew in his favour among the highly educated. Across the country, 12 per cent of voters who voted for the Congress in the last elections say they will vote for Modi if they get a chance. Proof perhaps that people believe in his development mantra. The overwhelming endorsement is also a proof that despite the controversies that have surrounded Modi these past few years, people are by and large taken in by his image as an absolutely incorruptible politician, something that sounds like an oxymoron these days.

Running a distant second behind Modi is Delhi Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit who last year created history of sorts by being elected to office for a third consecutive term. If the BJP in Delhi was confined to the opposition benches yet again in the Assembly elections held last November, it was largely due to Dikshit who is everyone's "genial aunt-next-door". Twenty three per cent of voters in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh say she is a better bet as chief minister than the local incumbent Mayawati while in faraway Kerala, the only state in the country where women outnumber men, 24 per cent of voters thought she was the best as against 31 that V.S. Achuthanandan got. Dikshit occupied the numero uno spot in the Chief Ministers' poll of 2005 and had slipped to fifth place last year, but has recovered to second spot now.

Until a couple of years ago, most Indians looked at Bihar in the way that the world now sees Pakistan—a failed state, where nothing ever works and anything can go wrong. Governance was a sham, the law and order situation was in a shambles and the state Assembly did not even pass a budget for five years and instead opted for the vote on account. And then Nitish Kumar came along. He laid particular emphasis on the health and education sectors, ensured that the allocations for roads were fully utilised to connect the state and cracked the whip on law offenders, not even hesitating to send his own partymen to jail for violations. Kumar does not have a pan-Indian image like Modi but 72 per cent voters in Bihar and 54 per cent in Jharkhand thought he was the best chief minister, his support base cutting across the urban-rural divide and age groups. With 10 per cent of the national vote, just one percentage point behind Dikshit, he occupies third place.

The poll has also painted a mixed picture of chief ministers at the national and state levels. Orissa's Naveen Patnaik takes top slot at the state level with a net popularity rating (NPR) of 84 (see box) but occupies 11th position at the national level. Uttarakhand's B.C. Khanduri is ranked third at the state level but is 18th nationally. This, of course, is no reflection on the BJP chief minister who is known to be doing a splendid job in Dehradun. It is just that as a low-profile chief minister of a tiny, hilly state, he doesn't quite get the national exposure that a Modi or a Dikshit would get. ■